



Louis XVI was executed in 1793. Using the guillotine as the only means of execution for all people—royals and paupers alike—was meant to reinforce the revolutionary principle of equality.

increasingly violent, politicized common folk, the *sans-culottes*—their name a reference to their striped, baggy trousers. There was an increasingly hostile stand-off between political factions in Paris, such as the Girondins and more extremist Jacobins, which attracted the support of the *sans-culottes*, and the French government.

An external threat

Whatever the obvious instability, progress toward a new social order was being made. In September 1791, a constitutional monarchy was proclaimed. Similarly, the church's privileged position was forcibly ended, though this, too, provoked lasting upheaval and violence. Equally critically, the freedom of the press was asserted.

At the same time, revolutionary France faced an external threat from Austria and Prussia, both determined to reassert the primacy of hereditary monarchy and to forestall revolutionary tendencies in their own countries. In April 1792, France declared war on both, a war that would continue, in different guises, for 23 years. By August, the combined Austrian and Prussian forces were within 100 miles (160 km) of Paris.

A kind of hysteria gripped the city. A mob stormed the Tuileries, where the royal family was held, slaughtering its Swiss Guards. The following month, a further round of killings, the September Massacres, was unleashed against anyone suspected of royalist sympathies. September 1792 also marked the establishment of the directly

elected National Convention and of the First French Republic. Almost its first act was to put Louis XVI on trial as a traitor. In January 1793, he was executed, an early victim of the guillotine, championed as a humane and egalitarian means of death.

The sense of crisis continued to grow. In April 1793, the Committee of Public Safety was created to safeguard the revolution. For a year or more, under the chairmanship of a provincial lawyer, Maximilien Robespierre, the most influential of the now-dominant Jacobins, it would effectively become the government of France. Its impact on France, however short-lived, was devastating. This was the Terror. Counterrevolutionary movements across the country were ruthlessly suppressed, most obviously in the Vendée region of the southwest, where up to 300,000 died. Churches proved particularly rich targets. The Terror's victims were less likely to be remaining aristocrats and more anyone Robespierre suspected of impure thoughts, including almost all of his political opponents.

Robespierre's single-minded pursuit of revolutionary purity reached an improbable climax with his creation in 1794 of a new religion, the Cult of the Supreme Being. It was intended as a focus of, and spur to, patriotic and revolutionary virtues, the superstition of the Catholic Church replaced by a belief dedicated to reason celebrating the natural laws of the universe. The megalomania it suggested contributed significantly to his sudden downfall, and at the end of July 1794, Robespierre was put to the guillotine.

Order restored

With the end of the killings—more particularly with the establishment of yet another government, the Directory, at the end of 1795—order of a sort was restored. Tellingly, it was achieved in part by the Directory's willingness to use force against the Paris mob, ordered by Napoleon Bonaparte, then a young general in the revolutionary army.

Furthermore, France's armies, boosted by mass conscription, were reversing early